Imam Ali Al Ridha

(PBUH)

IMAM ALI AR-RIDHA (PBUH)

Name:	Ali bin Musa
Parents:	Imam Musa Al-Kadhim (pbuh) & Sayyida Suttana (or Najma or Ummulbanin)
Kuniyya:	Abul Hasan
Titles:	Ar-Ridha, Zamin -e-Thamin, Gharibul Ghuraba, Alim e Ale Muhammad
Birth:	11th Dhulqa'da 148 AH
Death:	29th Safar 203 AH Buried in Mash-had, Iran

LIFE AND WORKS

Imam played a significant role in the educating of Muslims. He set examples of education through one's own conduct.

He saw a short period of the rule of Harun Rashid who had murdered his father. Harun Rashid also attempted to kill Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) but was unsuccessful. After Harun's death, his sons Amin

and Mamun fought for power. Mamun won with Amin being killed.
Immediately after becoming the Khalifa, Mamun according to the tradition started by Muawiya, had to name a successor (heir apparent). Mamun summoned Imam to come to his capital Marv sending a messenger to Madina to bring the Imam to him and specifying a certain route and sending a security force. The route he chose was not the normal route where a lot of Shia's lived.

On the way they entered a town called **Nishapur.** There the scholars and people requested Imam to tell them a hadith. Imam related the following hadith which is known as the hadith of the **golden chain.**
"My father Musa Al-Kadhim narrated to me from his father Ja'fer As-Sadiq from his father Mohammed Al-Baqir from his father Ali Zaynul Abedeen from his father , the martyr of Kerbala from his father Ali ibn Abu Talib saying :"My loved one, and the pleasure of my eyes, the Messenger of God (pbuh) told me once, that Jibrail told him from the Lord "The kalima of **La ilaha illallah** *is my fort; whoever said it would enter my fort; and*

whoever entered my fort was safe from my punishment".

Those who wrote down the hadith numbered twenty thousand.
People started reciting the Kalima when Imam put his hand up and continued: *"Yes, the kalima is Allah's fort. It will provide you with excellent safety but on one condition only and that is that you obey and follow us - the holy Imams in the progeny of the holy Prophet (pbuh).*

On reaching Marv Mamun forced Imam to accept the heir apparency (To be the leader after him). Imam accepted unwillingly.

WHY DID MAMUN WANT IMAM TO BE THE HEIR APPARENT?

1. To please the Shia public opinion in Khurasan and the surrounding areas. This would make it easier for Mamun to be accepted by the people there, and gain victory over his brother Amin.

2. To avoid clashes with those like the Alawids who had always threatened the Abbasids with various uprisings.

Mamun celebrated the occasion of Imam's acceptance of heir apparency. Imam only gave a short sermon saying after he had praised Allah *"We have over you a right appointed by the Prophet, and you have a right over us as well; so if you fulfil your duty towards us, we will be bound to perform our duty towards you"*.

Mamun ordered a new coin to be minted with Imam Ar-Ridha's name on it. Imam however knew that this would not last long.

Soon Mamun put Imam under constant watch. Imam used the position to spread the true word of Islam. Mamun's court was visited by thousands and Imam made an impact on their minds. His ahadith were widely recorded. Mamun who was fond of scholarly discussions, would arrange for intellectuals from Greece, Italy, India, etc. to come to his court and hold discussions with the Imam.

One day a Jewish scholar was brought by Mamun to debate with Imam. The scholar asked: *"How can you accept Muhammad to be the prophet of God when he showed no miracles?"*
Imam replied: *"The greatest of miracles of Allah is the human mind. It allows ideas to be thought through and reasoned out. Islam appeals to human reason. Man must accept God through reason and not through miracles ".*
The scholar did not have much to say after that answer.

Imam also encouraged greatly the remembrance of Imam Husayn (pbuh)

Mamun was never sincere in his behaviour towards Imam. Seeing the Imam's popularity increase disturbed him immensely, especially after the occasion when he requested Imam to lead Eid prayers as he was not well. He saw that even before Imam had reached the mosque the people had lined the streets and were reciting takbeer and it seemed that even the walls of Marv were doing the same. He had to ask Imam to go back that day.

TIMELINE

Year	Age	Event
767 CE **11** **Dhulqa'da** **148 AH**		Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) is born in Madina to Sayyida Suttana, (Najma, Tuktam, Khayzarun) from North Africa. One of 37 children. (Most of the Saadat are Musawi) The 6th Imam used to tell his companions to await the birth of his grandson who he addressed as *Alim e Ale Muhammad*.
768CE – 774CE **151 – 157 AH**	**3-9**	Muhammad ibn Mansur al-Mahdi becomes Khalifa and assures Imam Kadhim (pbuh) safety. Imam builds a suburb of Madina called Surba,which becomes a Learning Institute. Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) is under the tutorage of his father.

Year	Age	Event
781CE **164 AH**	**16**	The khalifa Al-Mahdi exiles Imam Kadhim (pbuh) to Baghdad where he is imprisoned for a year. Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) holds the fort at the Learning Institute.
785 CE **168 AH**	**20**	The khalifa Musa Al Hadi increases tyranny on the Shia at one time killing countless children from the lineage of the Prophet (pbuh). Imam Ridha (Pbuh) refers to this as a tragedy comparable to the day of ‘Ashura.
786 CE **169 AH**	**21**	Harun al-Rashid becomes khalifa. His reign is at the height of Abbasid rule. Despite being intellectually and politically resourceful he has a hatred for the Ahlulbayt just like his forefathers and systematically exiles the descendants of

Year	Age	Event
		Imam Ali (pbuh). Shias were terrorised. It was one of the worst periods of oppression for the Shias.
793 CE 173AH	**25**	Birth of Imam's sister Fatima al-Masuma Qum.
793 CE – 803 CE 174AH – 183 AH	**25 - 35**	Harun al-Rashid exiles and imprisons Imam Kadhim (pbuh) first to Basra and then to Baghdad. Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) sits in Masjidun Nabi and gives discourses on the building of a Muslim Umma (community). The Umma had fragmented and needed cohesion.
803CE 25 Rajab 183 AH	**35**	Imam Musa Al Kadhim (pbuh) is poisoned by Harun Rashid through Sind ibn Shahik on the 25 Rajab 183 AH. He is buried in Kadhmayn. Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) assumes Imama

Year	Age	Event
803 – 809 CE 183 – 190 AH	**35-42**	Imam's teaching activities are now monitored and restricted. The Abbasid Empire under Harun Rashid was known as the Golden Age. Oppression and injustice was masked by the promotion of knowledge through Baytul Hikma (the house of wisdom). Anyone who opposed the regime was brutally murdered. The followers of the Ahlulbayt a prime target.
809 CE 190 AH	**42**	Harun Rashid dies leaving a decree that the Islamic Empire be divided between his sons Amin (from his wife Zubaida) and Mamun (from a Persian slave Marajil) with Amin being his successor. They were born 6 months apart.

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809 CE – 813 CE 190 – 194 AH	**42-52**	Mamun (based in Khurasan, Iran) rejects the contract his father has made and embarks upon a civil war with his brother Amin (based in Baghdad). Baghdad suffers heavy losses and Amin is defeated and decapitated. Marv in Iran becomes the new capital of the Islamic Empire. Imam uses the time to teach. Scholars from all fields flock to Madina to learn from Imam.
814 CE 195 AH	**47**	Birth of Imam Muhammad Taqi (pbuh) to Sayyida Sabika (Khaizarun) in Madina.
819 CE 200 AH	**52**	Mamun requests Imam to present himself in Marv (Iran) to negotiate the future of the Khilafa.
819 CE 200 AH	**52**	On his way to Marv in Nishapur he makes a

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		declaration known as the hadith of the Golden chain – Divinity has declared:"The declaration 'There is no god but Allah', is My stronghold; whoever enters My stronghold is safe..." Then Imam said: "It (The Kalima) has conditions, and I am one of its conditions."
819 CE **200 AH**	**52**	To give legitimacy to his leadership, Mamun offers heir apparency to Imam. (Imam was 22 years older than Mamun). Imam's first stand towards the offer was to reject it and he continued to do so until he faced veiled and open threats of death, whence he accepted the heir apparency, "tearfully and sorrowfully". A coin is minted to mark the occasion.

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819 – 822 CE 200 – 203 AH	**52-55**	Mamun's court was visited by thousands and Imam made an impact on their minds. His ahadith were widely recorded. Mamun who was fond of scholarly discussions would arrange for intellectuals from Greece, Italy, India, etc. to come to his court and hold discussions with the Imam. Imam encouraged the remembrance of Imam Husayn (pbuh)
822 CE 203 AH	**55**	Seeing the Imam's popularity increase disturbed Mamun immensely especially after an occasion when he requested Imam to lead Eid prayers as he was not well. He saw that even before Imam had reached the mosque the people had lined the streets and and it

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		seemed that even the walls of Marv were reciting takbeer with Imam. He had to ask Imam to go back that day. He arranged for Imam to be poisoned with grapes.
822 CE 29 Safar 203 AH	**55**	Imam died in Toos in a village called Sanabad. Mamun ordered Imam's grave to be dug near his father Harun's and when it was being dug he said that Imam had told him that when his grave would be dug water and fish would appear underneath. Just as Imam had said when they finished digging a spring of water appeared with fish in it and then disappeared. Imam is buried there at what is today called Mash had in Iran.

The goal of the QF team is to change the way we learn about Islam to reach our personal best - to be the “Go to” place for student, teacher, parent, adult who missed out on Madrasa, or a curious individual just trying to make sense of Islam. Everything hinges around the concept that it is our duty to understand and be understood in order to reach our personal best.

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